There Has Possibly Been an Incident

By Chris Thorpe

SPEAKER: I'm listening to someone I have known for years, telling me, with restraint, something terrible. I know this Incident, to be terrible even though the man in front of me is not telling me the detail of it. I know this thing to be terrible because I said it was a good idea for it to happen. But still I need to be told in an untraceable way. We are both comfortable with this because we are aware of responsibilities higher than a responsibility to ourselves. And one of his responsibilities is to tell me, in person, news like this.

A long time ago now, I saw this man who is standing here in my office, in a tailored suit, save the life of another man and a woman, who, all things considered, probably deserved to die. I saw him commit one act of mercy and years later, here we are.

INTRODUCTION

Everyone tends to think of themselves as the hero of their own story, at the very least they know they're "right." What is your idea of heroism, of compromise, of individual and collective action? You see, its small acts of choosing or ***not*** *choosing that either pass unnoticed or send ripples around the world.*

Revolution . . . it's not just fading ink in history books. It's happening today. All over the world. Myanmar . . . Sudan . . . Ethiopia . . . Haiti . . . the 2021 attack on the US capitol. You don't get to vote on a revolution. That's kind of the point.

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SPEAKER: Years ago we stood on a balcony over a square that was no longer square. The edges of the buildings were so eroded, so pulverised by shellfire that there were no straight lines. We hadn't levelled this building because, I think, there was some agreement, that there would be a moment for people like us. People so long denied the chance to do so by the people entrenched in the building, to stand on that

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balcony just once as the proxies of everyone below.

I stood on the balcony and raised my arms with the others and the air was electric with promise and noise. The noise an, as yet, unformed roar, before the slogans were written that would carry us all into the future. And while we stood on the balcony, another man and a woman knew their time was finished, that the long, cruel game was over. They sat in straight-backed chairs and looked at the guns, and the tired young people -- Young, like we all were back then, younger than them by far. They would follow the tradition of deposed and hated rulers everywhere and in one of several possible ways, die.

That day on the balcony, the man who is now sitting in my office was the one who decided to fetch the two and bring them out onto the balcony for the last time. We were the focus for those “waiting to see what happened next” and also the “arbiters of what happened next.” In that situation, someone has to step forward and answer. What now? This. And we were turned into the people they so desperately wanted to see in front of them.

He installed our former rulers on the balcony as a centerpiece. The crowd shredded their throats. It's something I notice when I watch the footage of that moment. It's a reflex, surely, but I think I see the woman's lips pull up at the corners for a fraction of a second. Her hard-wired response to adulation -- forced adulation. Encased in its false worldview, her brain is unable to distinguish between the sound of forced love and the sound of pure hatred. We allowed them to stand for a long moment, bathed in light and noise. The noise congealed into peaks and troughs. The first new chant of a new era. The crowd, seeing their former rulers, has made its first decision about the new state of things, and that decision is. Kill them.

And, on the balcony that day, this is what happens. The moment that leads us to now, to here, today, this office, and what we have become. On the balcony, unexpectedly,

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to all of us, he lifts his right hand. The hand says. Silence. That's what the crowd interpret. And the crowd obey.

And he says, “This isn't about what we want right now. This isn't about revenge. *(Beat)* What do you want?” And the crowd say. Kill them. And he says, “I'm not here to tell you what should be done.” And the crowd say. Kill them. And he says, “Not yet. Let's think about the kind of society we want to build, now we have the chance. And someone in the crowd says, they've been killing us for years. And he says, “Yes. But do we want to go on living by the rules they created?”

And in that moment, we are separated from the crowd. We are holding our former oppressors at gunpoint. And we are also the crowd's hope, personified -- The new leaders deposing the old. In that moment him sitting there and me sitting here and all this *(gestures to the office around him)* becomes somehow inevitable.

The crowd no longer says kill them. Something in the appetite is gone. There's a shift. A feeling that we, the random collection of tired and ragged people on the balcony, flanking our former oppressors, have somehow taken responsibility. That we're being given a chance. If we're going to set ourselves apart. If we're going to refuse to do what the moment demands, then we had better damn well make ourselves responsible. We'd better, the crowd says. Ridiculous I know to treat a crowd like a thing of single intent, but there it is. We'd better have a plan.

And so we fall into it. Or step into it. On that balcony, on that day. Making promises designed to at least make it appear we know what we're doing. If we'd been asked to articulate our vision back then on the balcony, I don't think it would have included this. This moment, in this office, now. At that moment just after the old man and the old woman had disappeared inside to face a trial, just as soon as there was a system in place to try them. If we'd been asked, what do you want? What is your alternative? We'd have stared. And we'd have said. *(Beat)* Something else. We knew

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the answer needed to be better. It has taken us years to realize the answer would include this day -- This news -- This Incident.

We began to learn. We learned, for example, that for something worthwhile to happen it's simply not enough to wish the situation to be otherwise. It's simply not enough to wish the situation to be otherwise.

As the years progressed, I found I had an aptitude for leadership. I have done what had to be done. One day I will step away. But now, I'm still acting to structure the future. And that future is still something I believe in.

When I had to close the first newspaper, I did it because I believed in a future defined by free speech. When I asked for calm and quiet for the sake of stability, I believed in a future defined by the freedom to protest. The jail terms were brought in because people apparently just won't listen when we say that change is not something that happens overnight. Not if you want it to last.

It's not my fault. I told them loudly and honestly. People won't listen because that's how people are. And I said to the ones who objected to the jail terms, what would you rather we did? Remember that day on the balcony. We aren't murderers. We don't even murder our enemies. You wanted that. I'm only here to see my part of the job through and no more.

And I believe that. I'm only here, still, because I haven't finished safeguarding the future. As the man sitting opposite me tells me that the Incident, what had to happen, has happened. On my orders, my deniable orders of course, but still my orders, a small number of officers in one part of the army in a single city on the border full of spies and liars and agitators have shot some young soldiers who refused an order to fire on a demonstration. And then the army fired on the demonstrators anyway. They fired on the demonstrators anyway because I decided that had to happen.

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Of course, there'll be no trace of my part in this. The officers will be shown to have been acting alone, and they will be punished. We've become very good, over the years, at erasing the chain of command, up to and including conversations like this one. Because who in their right mind would order officers to execute young soldiers acting according to their conscience? And who in their right mind would order soldiers to fire on demonstrators? It happens. But who in their right mind would order it? Not us.

We started this with an act of mercy. A public act of mercy. One arm movement from one tired man, but we all stepped forward behind it. I stepped forward, as it turns out, further than the others. We started with an act of mercy, a public act of mercy. I don't know if we shouldn't have killed them. Thrown their bodies from the balcony to the crowd.

Today, there's another crowd below. I need to go and explain to them, that despite this Incident. This regrettable Incident. That nothing has changed. We're still heading in the right direction.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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